

While discovery is the best way to learn, this small guide might help you take your first steps.

If you're new to Gnome, you might be surprised that there is no Start menu. In fact, there are two panels – at the top of the screen and at the bottom of it. The bottom bar behaves just like the Windows XP taskbar where buttons will appear for every application window which will help you control the minimize, restore, focus and close functionality of the window. It might also have a trash button on the far right. Actually you can add a lot more functionality to the panel but by default, it does exactly what the Windows taskbar does minus shortcuts, toolbar icons, clock and start menu.

The top panel in its default layout will show you the clock, the toolbar icons of the applications that are running (and which you choose to appear there, e.g. VLC Media Player), networking and battery information and controls. It should also show you the system menus on the far right. The system menus contain three menus namely: Applications, Places and System.

Applications: menu will contain the installed software in a neat style organized in sections like 'Internet', 'Graphics', 'Office' etc. You'll find all your software here.

Places: menu will contain the links to your home, documents, music, pictures and any other bookmarked folders.

System: menu will contain the menus responsible for changing the settings of your system. It usually contains what the Windows control panel would contain.

Apart from this, you'd find things easy. We agree it will take time to be in tune with Gnome if you've been using KDE or Windows for a long time and have never used Gnome till now but once you've got the hang of it, you'll probably love it!

Where is everything?

The first mistake of a Windows user stepping into the Linux world would be to expect it to behave like Windows. You may expect to have your drives neatly laid out in the 'Computer' window, to have a 'My Documents' and a 'Start' button. While we've already told you that the Start button is missing in Gnome, we also need to tell you that Linux stores things a bit differently. Let's take the surprises one by one and uncover them.

Gnome has a computer window, and you'll find it in the Places system menu. This will list down the partitions on the computer. You can double-click one to open and read the contents. However, the concept of drives